friend forever.' The messaging was that the president had been forced by US public opinion to act against China, but the anti-Chinese measures were temporary and limited. In Congress, Bush made sure that 'dual use technology' with both civilian and military application continued to flow, including the sale of US satellites. Over the next two years, the World Bank, controlled by the US, sanctioned $4 billion worth of loans to China: no other country received as much. When the US needed China to support a UN resolution against Saddam Hussein in September 1990, Washington resumed high-level contacts (in the event the Chinese only abstained from voting). On human rights, missile and nuclear proliferation, and US support for China's entry to GATT, Beijing stuck to its positions, and on each issue Washington caved.[30]

Nevertheless, China–US relations were fraying. Beijing now moved to a more equidistant posture between Washington and Moscow. Gorbachev was in Beijing even as the Tiananmen protests were unfolding, but he avoided commenting on the situation. Despite the new democratic spirit of perestroika and glasnost in the USSR, Moscow's comments on the protests and subsequent repressive actions were subdued. When despite Bush's conciliatory stand the flow of US arms was stopped, Beijing turned to Moscow for weapons. Most importantly, the Soviets' border negotiations with China, which had been in progress since 1987, came to a head, and in 1991 the two sides came to an agreement on the border dispute.

Even as US–China economic relations flowered after the Tiananmen incident and China dramatically opened up to US goods and investment in the 1990s, trouble loomed. Anti-Western and particularly anti-US feelings were encouraged in China: the Chinese had been 'humiliated' by the West (and Japan) for a century, and a 'China that can say no' must now stand up. In the US, with Bill Clinton in the White House, human rights concerns in China again formed part of American policy. A growing view was that with the disappearance of the USSR, China was the principal threat to US supremacy and values. In 1995–96, when the Taiwanese president received a US visa to speak at his alma mater, Cornell University, Beijing's relations with Washington further deteriorated. In July 1995, China began to lob